The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

Donald Trump threatened to strike **Iranian power plants** and bridges on Tuesday if Iran's regime did not "open the fuckin' strait". This is the third time Mr Trump has threatened to attack civilian infrastructure, something which is generally considered a war crime under international law. Earlier Mr Trump boasted about the rescue of an American airman shot down by Iran on Friday.

Iran dismissed Mr Trump's expletive-laden ultimatum, calling it an "indication of a criminal mindset". A spokesperson for Iran's foreign ministry said his country would keep fighting "to defend our national security". Meanwhile, *Axios* reported that American and Iranian officials were discussing a potential "45-day ceasefire". But the American media outlet also suggested that the chances of reaching a deal were slim.

The prospect of the war escalating drove up **oil prices**. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped to above $110 a barrel during early trading in Asia. On Sunday OPEC+, a cartel of oil-producing countries and their allies, agreed to increase production by 206,000 barrels a day in May. But the announcement will be seen as largely inconsequential as long as the Strait of Hormuz remains closed.

Viktor Orban, **Hungary's** prime minister, convened an emergency meeting after explosives were found near a pipeline carrying gas from Russia. Opposition politicians accused his party of staging the incident ahead of elections next week. Mr Orban's populist-nationalist party is currently behind in the polls. Throughout his campaign, Mr Orban has blamed a "Kyiv-Brussels-Berlin" axis for conspiring to prevent Hungary from accessing cheap Russian fuel.

The **Democratic Republic of Congo** reached an agreement with the Trump administration to receive **migrants** deported from America, even if they came from third countries. The Congolese government said the first people will arrive this month. America has made similar deals with other African countries and last week made its first deportations to Uganda, sending eight people.

Pepsi canned its sponsorship of a big music festival in London over the appearance of **Ye**, formerly known as Kanye West, a controversial rapper. Ye has made antisemitic statements in the past and released a song called "Heil Hitler" (though he has apologised and denies being an antisemite). Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's prime minister, has criticised the festival's decision to book Ye.

Pope Leo appealed for peace in his first Easter mass. The American pontiff said "Let those who have the power to unleash wars choose peace." He did not name any conflicts, but he has recently become more forthright in his condemnation of some of the Trump administration's policies. This month he will make his first trip as pontiff to Africa, an increasingly important part of the world for Roman Catholicism.

Figure of the day: 3,000, the number of new outlets McDonald's is due to open in China in the next three years, in addition to its existing 7,000. Read the full story.

Photograph: ABEDIN TAHERKENAREH/EPA/Shutterstock

Donald Trump’s looming deadline for Iran

On Monday, after the White House’s Easter Egg Roll, Donald Trump will give a press conference. Expect him to boast about America’s rescue of an airman shot down in Iran.

The mission was undoubtedly difficult, and the stakes were high. Had the Iranian regime found the airman first he would likely have become a source of leverage, alongside the Strait of Hormuz. Captured pilots often take on totemic significance in American wars.

But the rescue has not cooled the temperature of the conflict. Monday is the deadline Mr Trump set for Iran to either make a deal with America or reopen the Strait (or it was—a cryptic social media post saying only “Tuesday, 8:00 PM Eastern Time” suggests he may have extended it). Over the weekend he issued aggressive warnings about striking civilian infrastructure on Tuesday if Iran does not comply. Threatening such acts—which are generally considered war crimes—shows how little in this conflict is going America’s way. No wonder he would rather focus on tales of derring do.

Photograph: Getty Images

English doctors down stethoscopes (again)

Early on Tuesday morning more than 50,000 resident doctors in England will go on strike for the 15th time in three years. The group, who represent almost half of all doctors in the country, are embroiled in a bitter dispute with the government over pay, which has been declining in real terms since 2008 (despite a 22% pay rise in 2024).

The strikes are a major headache for the National Health Service. Millions of patients still languish on waiting lists; emergency services are stretched dangerously thin. Strikes will force hospitals to cancel thousands of routine appointments and scheduled surgeries. To keep essential services going the NHS must find around £300m ($397m) for senior doctors to cover shifts.

In response, the government has withdrawn an offer to create 1,000 specialised training posts, arguing that it can no longer afford them. This has made doctors even more annoyed. They complain of being burned out, and of spiralling student debt and rising demands. Many are threatening to find work abroad instead.

Photograph: Getty Images

Emmanuel Macron’s party looks to his successor

Ten years ago on Monday Emmanuel Macron launched En Marche!, a centrist movement, in his home town of Amiens. He used it to win the French presidential election a year later. But there are very few plans to celebrate the anniversary, partly due to differences among centrists over his succession. That race is now under way.

The president’s party, now called Renaissance, is led by Gabriel Attal, a former prime minister. Mr Attal probably wants to run for the presidency in 2027, and has distanced himself from the unpopular Mr Macron. Polls, however, suggest that Edouard Philippe, another ex-prime minister, is better placed to beat either Jordan Bardella or Marine Le Pen from the populist right in a second round run-off. On the centre-right Bruno Retailleau, the Republicans’ leader, and David Lisnard, the mayor of Cannes, have also suggested that they will stand. The already crowded field is likely to become even more so.

Photograph: Getty Images

Method in the madness

Anyone living with a basketball fan will have noticed a strange malady in recent weeks: distraction, sleeplessness, emotional volatility and constant talk of “bracketology”. The affliction, known as “March Madness”, is caused by an American college-basketball tournament. Over three weeks, dozens of teams are whittled down to one champion thanks to a ruthless single-elimination knockout format. The men’s final takes place on Monday in Indianapolis.

The competition has been around since 1939. It is not just the action on the court that counts. Millions of people aim to predict the outcome. Workplaces have bracket pools in which colleagues vie to pick the most games right. Because of the unpredictability of the tournament—upsets and chaotic victories abound—a complete basketball novice can win cash and bragging rights. On Sunday, in the women’s final, UCLA beat South Carolina. In the men’s final Michigan will play Connecticut. Polymarket, a big prediction market, currently gives Michigan a 73% chance of winning.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Who is the President of the European Central Bank?

Violence is the last refuge of the incompetent.

Isaac Asimov